BIOGRAPHY

SWABIR SHARIFF

Founder & Executive Director, The Good Guides · Leadership Speaker and Advisor



"Changing the starting line for young people — not cheering them on from it."

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10,000+
YOUNG PEOPLE MENTORED ACROSS TORONTO SINCE 2020

1 of 100
QECT 100 YOUNG LEADERS AWARDEE 2026

2020
FOUNDED THE GOOD GUIDES IN SCARBOROUGH — YOUTH-LED, ON THE GROUND SINCE DAY ONE

BIOGRAPHY

Born and raised in Scarborough, Swabir Shariff grew up in Toronto Community Housing. He watched the people around him — friends, and his own brother — get pulled toward the justice system, while the services meant to help them never reached them: young people could not see themselves in those organizations, had no mentors, and were handed solutions designed by outsiders. So they disengaged entirely.

His executive career came first. As a Director of Security in Scarborough, leading round-the-clock (24/7) operations for a major retail centre, he watched young people drift through his corridors every day, skipping school, and started informal hangouts with them, right there. The Good Guides grew out of those conversations: founded in 2020, while he was still in the role, and built as a youth-led mentoring organization — services designed with young people holding the keys, not prescribed at them. He later stepped away from that career to lead it full time.

Its work spans mentorship, youth leadership, violence prevention, sports and co-op placements. Since 2020, The Good Guides has mentored 10,000+ young people aged 11–18 across Toronto, and Swabir has helped direct over a million dollars in investment into The Good Guides and other Scarborough youth initiatives. In October 2026, that work carried him to London: selected as one of the QECT 100 Young Leaders, he presented at Asprey, and was received at St James's Palace, at a reception given by His Majesty King Charles III and Her Majesty Queen Camilla.

> *"The services didn't fail because people didn't care. They failed because the young people they were built for couldn't see themselves in them. So we built something they could."*

RECOGNITION

QECT 100 Young Leaders Awardee 2026
The Queen Elizabeth II Commonwealth Trust (QECT) 100 Young Leaders Awards 2026. Presented at Asprey in London in October 2026.

One Young World Ambassador
Featured in the Ambassador Spotlight, September 2026. Attended One Young World as a Global Delegate in 2025.

Scarborough Walk of Fame — Rising Star
Inducted April 2024, for founding The Good Guides and leading full-time youth engagement and violence prevention in Scarborough.

CharityVillage — Best Individual Contribution to Youth Engagement
Awarded in 2021, the award's inaugural year, for opening doors for young people through The Good Guides.

National media have turned to his voice on youth violence and community leadership — Global News "Making a Difference" (December 2021) and CP24 Tonight (February 2022) among them.

SELECTED SPEAKING ENGAGEMENTS · 2023–2025

- Keynote — Toronto Police Service College
- Keynote — OPTrust
- Remarks — Scarborough Walk of Fame induction
- Panels — post-secondary institutions
- Talks and panels — organizational events, private businesses
- Talks — Toronto high schools and elementary schools